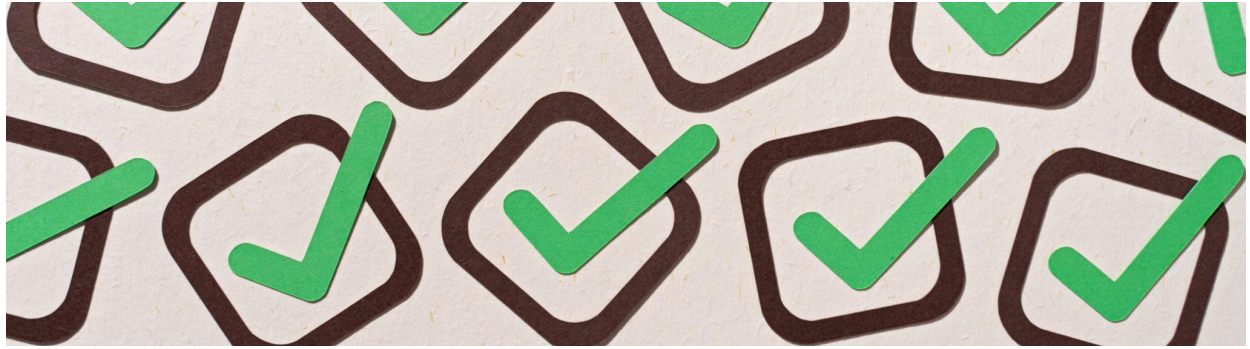


Overview



Status Completed ▾

Travel Documents & UK Entry Requirements

While U.S. military members and Department of Defense (DoD) federal civilian employees entering the United Kingdom on official PCS assignments are completely exempt from standard visa and Electronic Travel Authorization (ETA) requirements, they must maintain distinct documentation to cross the border smoothly. Military personnel must travel with their official NATO travel orders, a valid military ID, and a standard personal tourist passport. Although active-duty personnel traditionally rely on their military ID and orders for official entry, carrying a tourist passport is essential to avoid boarding friction with commercial airlines and remains mandatory for any personal leisure travel outside the UK.

Concurrently, this ETA exemption extends directly to authorized family members traveling on official orders. Command-sponsored military dependents must possess a blue No-Fee passport (stamped for official government use), while authorized DoD civilian dependents must possess a maroon Official passport alongside the sponsor's PCS orders to legally enter and establish residency, as family members do not share the same NATO order entry privileges as the active-duty member. To guarantee a seamless check-in with commercial airlines, families should present these official passports and relocation orders together.

TRAVEL DOCUMENTS

☐ NATO ORDERS

NATO travel orders grant U.S. military members official permission to transit and perform duty within the United Kingdom. This document works alongside your military ID card to exempt you from standard immigration barriers, including visa requirements and the UK Electronic Travel Authorization (ETA). Because it proves your assignment is bound by the NATO Status of Forces Agreement (SOFA), it is recommended that you carry

multiple physical copies to present to both commercial airline agents at check-in and UK Border Force officers upon arrival.

☐ **TOURIST PASSPORT**

Military members, DoW Civilians and Command-sponsored family members must obtain a tourist passport for leisure travel to other countries. Travelers planning to perform unofficial (personal) travel during or in conjunction with their official overseas assignments, should obtain a Regular (Tourist) Passport prior to departure from CONUS at their own expense.

☐ **NO FEE PASSPORT**

A No-Fee Passport is required for command-sponsored dependents (spouses and children) of U.S. military members moving on Permanent Change of Station (PCS) orders to the United Kingdom. Its core purpose is to serve as the official, government-subsidized legal vessel that permits family members to entry-check, reside, and establish long-term status in the host nation. The process to obtain this status typically takes 8 to 10 weeks. The family must first apply for the physical No-Fee passport through their losing installation's base passport office by submitting standard passport applications backed by the sponsor's official PCS orders.

☐ **OFFICIAL PASSPORT**

DoW civilian employees and their command-sponsored family members must possess an Official Passport (maroon cover) to execute a Permanent Change of Station (PCS) to the United Kingdom. Because civilian personnel do not travel under active-duty military NATO orders, the U.S. Government requires

the maroon Official passport to formally certify their status as federal direct-hires or authorized dependents on official government business. This document serves as the mandatory legal vessel to secure their UK Entry Clearance Visa or Digital Record of Exemption prior to leaving the United States. Crucially, the Official passport is strictly restricted to government-directed travel; families must still obtain and carry personal tourist passports (blue cover) to pass through border control for any leisure trips or vacations outside the UK during their tour.

Military Member Checklist

- ☐ NATO Orders
- ☐ Tourist Passport

Military Member Dependent Checklist

- ☐ No Fee Passport
- ☐ Tourist Passport

DoW Civilian and Family Member Checklist

- ☐ Official Passport
- ☐ Tourist Passport

COMMAND SPONSORSHIP

Military Dependents

Military families **must explicitly receive Command Sponsorship**. Simply being enrolled in DEERS does not automatically authorize a dependent to move overseas with a service member.

The service member must apply through their losing command. Every family member must undergo an Exceptional Family Member Program

(EFMP) screening to ensure the gaining UK installation (such as RAF Lakenheath) has the medical and educational infrastructure to support them. Once approved, the dependents are explicitly listed on the sponsor's PCS orders. This opens up government-funded travel, higher housing allowances (OHA), and eligibility for No-Fee passports and the UK Exemption Vignette.

DoD Civilian Dependents

DoD federal civilian employees do not use the term "Command Sponsorship." Instead, their families must be designated as **"Authorized Dependents"** on the employee's official travel orders.

During the hiring or relocation phase, the civilian employee submits dependency verification to their Human Resources specialist. While they do not do a military command sponsorship board, civilian families moving OCONUS must still complete a medical clearance screening to ensure their healthcare needs can be met by local clinics or the local British healthcare system.

If cleared, the dependents are written directly onto the civilian's DD Form 1614 (Civilian PCS Orders). This lists them as authorized travelers, allowing the government to pay for their flights, household goods relocation, and authorizing them to receive an Official Passport (maroon cover) and a UK Entry Clearance Visa.

RAF Lakenheath Passport Office

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<https://lakenheathfss.com/military-personnel-flight/>